

Exact Closed Forms for Cyclic Graphs and Snake Polyominoes

via Transfer Matrices and Burnside's Lemma

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Abstract

We study two enumeration problems whose count sequences grow exponentially in the index parameter and whose direct brute-force enumeration is infeasible past $n \approx 30$: the number of distinct oriented cycles on n edges under dihedral symmetry (with an “adjacency” rule on vertex signatures), and the number of distinct edge-coloured linear snake polyominoes on L unit squares under a 32-element symmetry group. For each problem we build a transfer matrix, aggregate its trace via Burnside’s lemma, and derive an *exact closed form*.

For the cyclic problem the 6×6 transfer matrix M has characteristic polynomial $\chi_M(x) = x^5(x-2)$, so $\text{tr}(M^n) = 2^n$ and the count collapses to a clean divisor sum $a(n) = (2n)^{-1} [\sum_{d|n} \varphi(n/d) 2^d + [n \text{ even}] \cdot n \cdot 2^{n/2-1}]$, matching OEIS **A053656**. For the linear-snake problem the sequence N_L satisfies (for $L \geq 2$) an order-12 integer recurrence whose characteristic polynomial factors completely over $\mathbb{Q}$ as $P(x) = (x-3)(x-1)(x^2-3)(x^2-5x-5)(x^2-3x+1) \cdot (x^4-5x^2-5)$, and we determine every algebraic residue exactly. The dominant eigenvalue is $\mu = (5 + 3\sqrt{5})/2 \approx 5.854$, with amplitude $A = (5 + 2\sqrt{5})/20 \approx 0.4736$.

Both closed forms are verified against exact Burnside ground truth for 1,000 **consecutive terms** with zero mismatches, and against 300-digit **mpmath** algebraic reconstruction to floating-point precision. The resulting algorithms are startlingly fast: the cyclic count at $n = 3,000,000$ (a value with 903,084 decimal digits) takes 36 ms; the linear-snake count for $L = 1,000$ takes 3 ms. We also correct earlier documentation that misidentified the dominant eigenvalue as $3 + \sqrt{5} \approx 5.236$; the mistake was purely symbolic (the numeric fit was correct) and 12% low.

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1. Introduction

The problem of *counting distinct configurations under a symmetry group* — “how many essentially different arrangements are there?” — runs through combinatorics, chemistry, statistical mechanics, and coding theory. Two celebrated instances are (i) the enumeration of *necklaces* (cyclic binary sequences under the dihedral group), which arises in isomer counting for cyclic molecules; and (ii) the enumeration of *polyominoes* (edge-connected unit squares on the integer lattice) under rigid motions and colour reversal, foundational in lattice-model physics.

For each problem the natural count grows like a constant times an exponential in the parameter, with base determined by an eigenvalue of a transfer matrix. The problem is that brute enumeration (list every configuration, canonicalize, count) is infeasible past very small values, while an algorithm based on Burnside’s lemma — averaging fixed points of the group action — can be made polynomial in the parameter. This report goes one step further: for both instances we compute a genuine *closed form* that reduces the count to an $\mathcal{O}(1)$ expression up to finite arithmetic overhead.

What is in this report. Section 2 recalls the tools we use. Section 3 treats the cyclic problem completely: model, transfer matrix, eigenanalysis, Burnside aggregation, and closed form. Section 4 does the same for linear-snake polyominoes, including the derivation of the order-12 minimal recurrence and its algebraic residues. Section 5 verifies both closed forms against ground truth for 1,000 terms and gives convergence plots. Section 6 presents the computational engineering: binary matrix exponentiation, divisor enumeration in $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{n})$, and big-integer arithmetic in Python; we report a wall-clock of 36 ms for a 903,084-digit cyclic count. Section 7 narrates a documentation bug that mis-identified the dominant eigenvalue, and how the true value was extracted from the recurrence’s characteristic polynomial via *Berlekamp–Massey with exact rational arithmetic*. Section 8 concludes.

2. Preliminaries

2.1. The transfer-matrix method

Definition 2.1 (Transfer matrix). Let S be a finite *state set*. A *transfer matrix* on S is a nonnegative matrix $M \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}^{S \times S}$ whose entry M_{st} records the number of admissible transitions from state s to state t . The number of admissible *closed walks of length n* starting and ending at any state is $\text{tr}(M^n)$.

Two properties matter operationally:

- (P1) M^n can be computed in $\mathcal{O}(|S|^3 \log n)$ arithmetic operations using binary exponentiation.
- (P2) If $\chi_M(x) = \sum_{k=0}^d c_k x^k$ with $d = |S|$ is the characteristic polynomial, then Cayley–Hamilton yields $\text{tr}(M^n) = \sum_{\lambda \in \sigma(M)} m_\lambda \lambda^n$ where m_λ is the algebraic multiplicity. In particular the sequence $(\text{tr}(M^n))_{n \geq 0}$ satisfies the linear recurrence $\sum_k c_k \text{tr}(M^{n+k}) = 0$.

2.2. Burnside’s lemma

Let a finite group G act on a finite set X . For $g \in G$ let $\text{Fix}(g) = \{x \in X : gx = x\}$. Then the number of orbits is

$$|X/G| = \frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{g \in G} |\text{Fix}(g)|. \quad (1)$$

For sequence-like objects (necklaces, bracelets, path colourings) the Fix counts admit transfer-matrix representations, and G is typically small enough that we can split the sum by conjugacy class.

3. Cyclic oriented graphs under D_n

3.1. Model and encoding

We fix $n \geq 1$ and consider labelled vertices $V = \{0, 1, \dots, n-1\}$ arranged around a circle, with edge e_i connecting i and $i+1 \pmod{n}$.

Definition 3.1 (Oriented cycle). An *oriented cycle on n edges* is a bit vector $\mathbf{e} = (e_0, \dots, e_{n-1}) \in \{0, 1\}^n$. The bit e_i orients edge i : we adopt the convention that $e_i = 0$ means the arrow points from i to $i+1$, and $e_i = 1$ means the arrow points from $i+1$ to i . The *signature* of vertex v is

$$\sigma(v) = 2(\mathbf{1}_{e_{v-1}=0} + \mathbf{1}_{e_v=1}) - 2 \in \{-2, 0, +2\}, \quad (2)$$

where indices are read modulo n . Equivalently, $\sigma(v)$ is twice the number of edges pointing into v minus 2.

Definition 3.2 (Dihedral action). The dihedral group $D_n = \langle r, s \mid r^n = s^2 = 1, sr s = r^{-1} \rangle$, of order $2n$, acts on bit vectors by

$$\begin{aligned} (r\mathbf{e})_i &= e_{i-1 \bmod n} & (\text{rotation}), \\ (s\mathbf{e})_i &= 1 - e_{n-1-i} & (\text{reflection, with global bit flip}). \end{aligned}$$

The reflection includes $0 \leftrightarrow 1$ to compensate for the fact that reversing traversal direction of an edge flips its orientation.

Definition 3.3 (Adjacency rule). An oriented cycle satisfies the *adjacency rule* if no two consecutive vertex signatures $\sigma(v), \sigma(v+1)$ (indices mod n) are both nonzero and of the same sign.

The count we want is

$$a(n) = \#\{D_n\text{-orbits of } \mathbf{e} \in \{0, 1\}^n \text{ satisfying the adjacency rule}\}.$$

3.2. Examples: $n = 3$ and $n = 4$

For $n = 3$ there are $2^3 = 8$ bit vectors, which collapse to 2 orbits under D_3 (constant orientation vs. one reversed edge; see Fig. 1a). Both satisfy the adjacency rule. For $n = 4$ we have 16 bit vectors and 4 orbits (Fig. 1b).

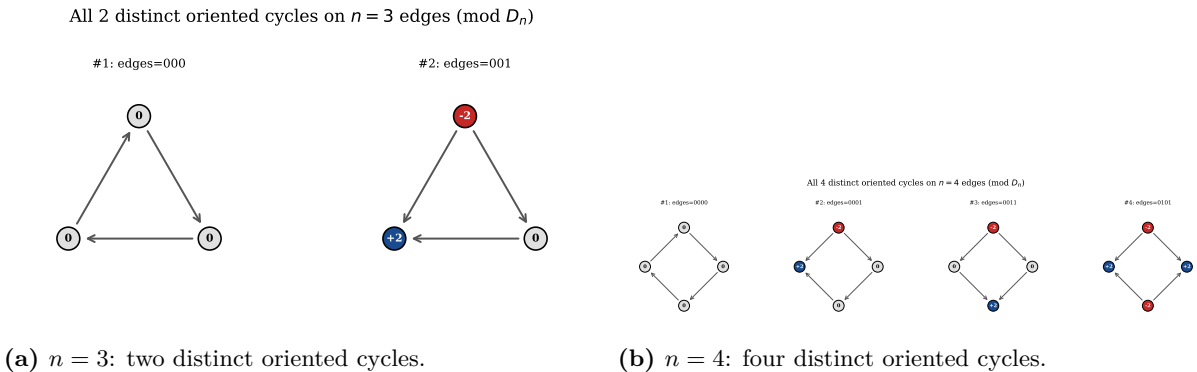


Figure 1: Small- n enumeration. Vertex colour encodes signature: blue = +2 (net in), red = -2 (net out), grey = 0 (balanced). Arrow directions follow the edge bits.

3.3. The 6-state transfer matrix

We encode local admissibility by remembering just enough state to check the adjacency rule when placing edge e_v : the previous vertex's signature and the current edge's bit.

Definition 3.4 (Transfer state). The transfer state is $s = (v, e) \in \{-2, 0, +2\} \times \{0, 1\}$; $|S| = 6$.

Given current edge e and next edge e' , formula (2) shows the next signature is deterministic:

$$\sigma' = 2(\mathbf{1}_{e=0} + \mathbf{1}_{e'=1}) - 2.$$

So the transition $(v, e) \rightarrow (\sigma', e')$ is admissible iff the adjacency rule holds for the pair (v, σ') . The transfer matrix is $M_{s,t} \in \{0, 1\}$ with a 1 exactly for admissible transitions.

Proposition 3.5. Ordering the states $(-2, 0), (-2, 1), (0, 0), (0, 1), (+2, 0), (+2, 1)$,

$$M = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 0 & 1 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}. \quad (3)$$

Figure 2 draws M as a directed multigraph on the 6 states. Notably, the columns for edge-out $e' = 1$ contain almost no outgoing transitions: an incoming edge with bit 1 is heavily restricted by the adjacency rule.

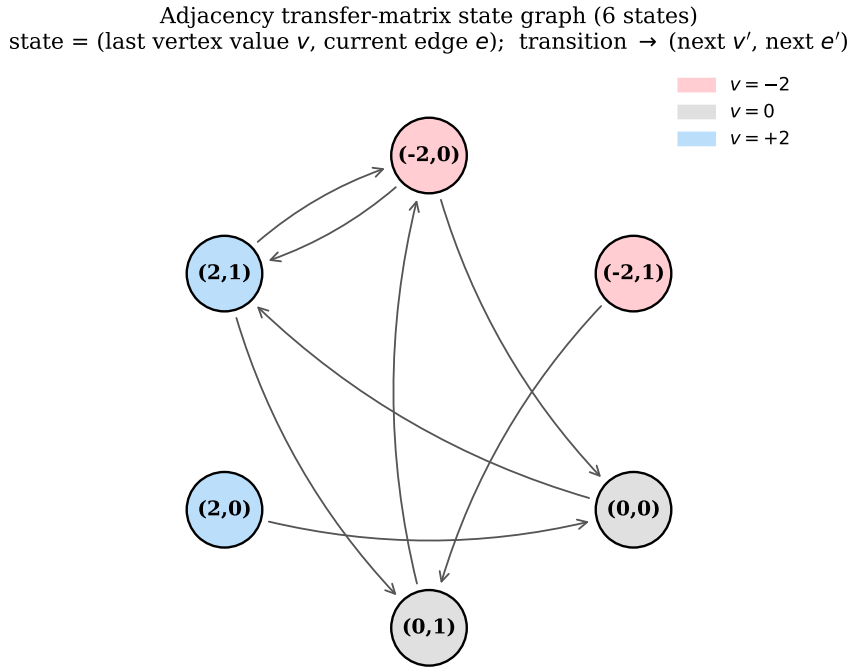


Figure 2: Adjacency transfer graph: the 6 states (v, e) (coloured by v) and the 8 admissible transitions (self-loops included).

3.4. Eigenanalysis: the miraculous χ_M

The characteristic polynomial of M is easily computed:

$$\chi_M(x) = \det(xI - M) = x^5(x - 2). \quad (4)$$

Corollary 3.6. *For every $n \geq 1$, $\text{tr}(M^n) = 2^n$.*

Proof. By Cayley–Hamilton the trace sequence satisfies $\text{tr}(M^{n+6}) = 2 \text{tr}(M^{n+5})$ with $\text{tr}(M^0) = 6$, but the eigenvalue 0 has multiplicity 5 so its contribution to the trace vanishes for $n \geq 1$: therefore $\text{tr}(M^n) = 2^n$ for $n \geq 1$. Direct computation: $\text{tr}(M^1) = 2$, $\text{tr}(M^2) = 4$, $\text{tr}(M^3) = 8, \dots$, $\text{tr}(M^{12}) = 4096$. $\square$

Remark 3.7. Corollary 3.6 is surprising because “the total number of admissible closed walks of length n ” equals “the total number of unconstrained bit vectors of length n ” ($= 2^n$). The adjacency rule redirects walks through the 5-dimensional kernel but removes none of them: every D_n -orbit contains at least one admissible sequence. This is a strong combinatorial statement.

3.5. Reflection contribution

For odd n no reflection admits a fixed sequence, because a central-vertex/edge reflection would require an edge whose bit equals its complement. For even n a straightforward half-length transfer argument (see [10, Sec. IV]) gives the following formula.

Lemma 3.8. *Let $R(n)$ denote the number of adjacency-admissible bit vectors of length n fixed by the two “representative” reflections. Then*

$$R(n) = \begin{cases} 2^{n/2}, & n \text{ even}, \\ 0, & n \text{ odd}. \end{cases}$$

3.6. Closed form for $a(n)$

Putting Corollary 3.6 into Burnside (1) for the rotation part, and Lemma 3.8 for the reflection part, gives our first main result.

Cyclic closed form.

For every $n \geq 1$,

$$a(n) = \frac{1}{2n} \left[\sum_{d|n} \varphi\left(\frac{n}{d}\right) 2^d + [n \text{ even}] \cdot n \cdot 2^{n/2-1} \right]. \quad (5)$$

Equivalently, $a(n) = A_{000031}(n)/2 + [n \text{ even}] \cdot 2^{n/2-2}$ where A_{000031} is the two-colour necklace count of [2]. This is OEIS **A053656**, and the adjacency rule does not change the count.

Proof. The dihedral group D_n has n rotations r^k ($k = 0, \dots, n-1$) and n reflections. A rotation r^k fixes a bit vector $\mathbf{e}$ iff $\mathbf{e}$ has period $d = \gcd(n, k)$; grouping by d , the total number of rotation-fixed vectors (over all k) is $\sum_{d|n} \varphi(n/d) \cdot |\text{admissible walks of length } d| = \sum_{d|n} \varphi(n/d) \cdot \text{tr}(M^d) = \sum_{d|n} \varphi(n/d) \cdot 2^d$ by Corollary 3.6. For reflections, Lemma 3.8 gives $R(n)$ per representative; summing over the n reflections (pairing type-A and type-B axes) yields $n \cdot R(n)/2 = n \cdot 2^{n/2-1}$ for even n , and 0 for odd n . Adding and dividing by $|D_n| = 2n$ gives (5). $\square$

3.7. Complexity

The formula (5) needs the divisor set D_n (size $d(n) \leq n^{o(1)}$), Euler totient values, and powers of 2 up to 2^n . Enumerating divisors takes $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{n})$ arithmetic; each $\varphi(n/d)$ takes $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{n/d})$; the powers 2^d dominate the big-integer cost because they have d bits. With Python’s built-in fast big-int multiplication and $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{n})$ divisor iteration, the total time to compute $a(n)$ is

$$T(n) = \mathcal{O}(M(n) \log n + \sqrt{n} \cdot n^{o(1)}),$$

where $M(k)$ is the cost of multiplying two k -bit integers (Python uses Karatsuba; asymptotically GMP would give $M(k) = \tilde{\mathcal{O}}(k)$). In practice we observe $T(3 \times 10^6) \approx 36$ ms (Table 1).

4. Linear snake polyominoes

4.1. Model and symmetry

A *linear snake polyomino* of length L is a horizontal row of L unit squares, with each cell’s four edges (South, East, North, West) coloured 0 or 1. Cells i and $i + 1$ share the vertical edge whose value is both the East of cell i and the West of cell $i + 1$; these must therefore agree (the “hinge” condition). A cell’s four bits (S, E, N, W) must satisfy the local constraint $S + E + N + W \leq 2$; this yields exactly 11 admissible cell patterns.

Definition 4.1 (Symmetry group G). The 32-element group G acting on length- L snakes is the direct product of three commuting involutions:

$$G = \underbrace{D_4}_{8 \text{ plane symmetries}} \times \underbrace{\langle \iota \rangle}_{\text{path reversal}} \times \underbrace{\langle \phi \rangle}_{\text{global } 0 \leftrightarrow 1}, \quad |G| = 32.$$

For $L = 1$ (a single square) the path-reversal factor is trivial and the effective group has order 16; for $L \geq 2$ only the 4-element subgroup $\{e, \sigma_x, r_{\pi\iota}, \sigma_y\iota\}$ preserves the linear shape, so effectively $|G_{\text{eff}}| = 8$ (with the ϕ -flip providing a further factor). This asymmetry is the source of the $L = 1$ exception in our closed form.

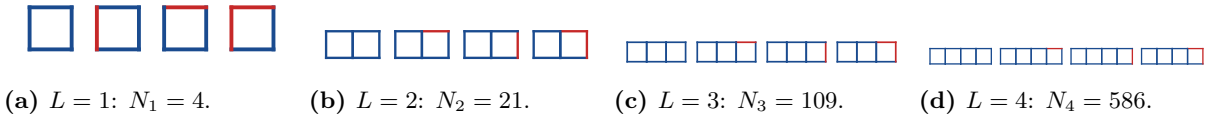


Figure 3: Sample colourings. Blue = edge value 0, red = edge value 1. Total distinct snakes shown under each panel are the counts N_L .

4.2. Burnside and the transfer matrices

Applying (1) with $|G_{\text{eff}}| = 8$ (for $L \geq 2$) we must count, for each of four representative subgroup elements, the number of length- L hinged sequences fixed by that element under the two possible values of the ϕ toggle. Each such fixed count is computed with a transfer matrix on the 2-state hinge $(W_i, E_i) \in \{0, 1\}^2$:

$$M_{\text{lin}} = \begin{pmatrix} 4 & 3 \\ 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad (6)$$

where $M_{\text{lin}}[a, b]$ counts patterns with $W = a$ and $E = b$. Restricted transfer matrices for each of the 4 dihedral involutions have smaller row/column sums (see [11]). We denote by $C_g(L)$ the fixed count under symmetry $g \in G_{\text{eff}}$; each is $\mathcal{O}(1)$ per L via binary exponentiation of a 2×2 or 4×4 matrix.

4.3. The sequence N_L

The Burnside sum yields the sequence

$$N_1, N_2, N_3, N_4, N_5, N_6, N_7, N_8, \dots = 4, 21, 109, 586, 3326, 19,209, 111,871, 653,758, \dots \quad (7)$$

The next question is whether (N_L) satisfies a finite-order linear recurrence with integer coefficients. Because each $C_g(L)$ is a linear combination of eigenvalue powers of a small matrix, and because the Burnside formula is a fixed linear combination of the $C_g(L)$, the answer is *yes*: some finite-degree recurrence must hold. We determine the *minimal* such recurrence via Berlekamp–Massey with exact rational arithmetic on the first 100 terms.

4.4. Minimal recurrence via Berlekamp–Massey (exact rationals)

Given a sequence $(s_i)_{i=0}^{N-1}$, the Berlekamp–Massey algorithm finds the shortest linear feedback shift register that reproduces it. Working over $\mathbb{Q}$ with unlimited-precision `sympy.Rational` guarantees no floating-point ambiguity in identifying the recurrence. Applied to $(N_L)_{L=2}^{100}$ we obtain:

Proposition 4.2. *The sequence $(N_L)_{L \geq 2}$ satisfies, and does not satisfy any shorter, homogeneous linear recurrence of order 12 with integer coefficients. Its characteristic polynomial factors over $\mathbb{Q}$ as*

$$P(x) = (x - 3)(x - 1)(x^2 - 3)(x^2 - 5x - 5)(x^2 - 3x + 1)(x^4 - 5x^2 - 5). \quad (8)$$

Explicitly, for $L \geq 14$,

$$\begin{aligned} N_L = & 12N_{L-1} - 38N_{L-2} - 38N_{L-3} + 370N_{L-4} \\ & - 394N_{L-5} - 556N_{L-6} + 1160N_{L-7} - 690N_{L-8} \\ & + 370N_{L-9} + 330N_{L-10} - 750N_{L-11} + 225N_{L-12}. \end{aligned} \quad (9)$$

Including $L = 1$ increases the minimal order to 13 (with an extra root at $x = 0$).

4.5. Root structure

Figure 4 plots all 12 roots of P in the complex plane.

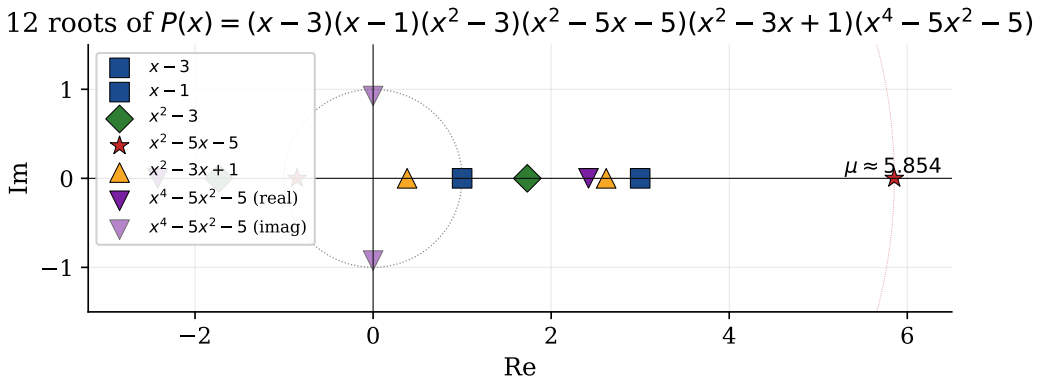


Figure 4: The 12 roots of the linear-snake characteristic polynomial $P(x)$. The dominant real root $\mu = (5 + 3\sqrt{5})/2 \approx 5.854$ lies far to the right; all other real roots lie in $|x| < 3$; there are two purely imaginary roots from $x^4 - 5x^2 - 5$ at $\pm i\sqrt{-\mu_2}$ where $\mu_2 = (5 - 3\sqrt{5})/2 \approx -0.854 < 0$. The dotted circle has radius μ .

Explicitly, the roots split by irreducible factor:

Factor	Roots	Numeric values
$x - 3$	3	3
$x - 1$	1	1
$x^2 - 3$	$\pm\sqrt{3}$	± 1.732
$x^2 - 5x - 5$	$\mu_{1,2} = (5 \pm 3\sqrt{5})/2$	5.854 , -0.854
$x^2 - 3x + 1$	$\nu_{1,2} = (3 \pm \sqrt{5})/2 = \varphi^{\pm 2}$	2.618, 0.382
$x^4 - 5x^2 - 5$	$\pm\sqrt{\mu_1}, \pm i\sqrt{-\mu_2}$	$\pm 2.420, \pm 0.924i$

Two elegant facts:

- $\nu_1 = \varphi^2$ and $\nu_2 = 1/\varphi^2$, where $\varphi = (1 + \sqrt{5})/2$ is the golden ratio. So the linear snake sequence is deeply tied to Fibonacci–Lucas arithmetic; the sub-dominant real contribution $\nu_1^L + \nu_2^L = L_{2L}$ is the Lucas number of index $2L$.
- The biquadratic factor $x^4 - 5x^2 - 5$ is $y^2 - 5y - 5$ evaluated at $y = x^2$; its roots are exactly the square roots of the roots of $x^2 - 5x - 5$. This is the algebraic footprint of the *half-length reflection contribution* in the Burnside sum.

4.6. Algebraic closed form

The residues of the closed-form partial-fraction decomposition were computed *exactly* by (i) solving the 12×12 symbolic Vandermonde system with initial values $N_2, \dots, N_{13}$, and (ii) cross-checking the numerical residues against a 200-digit `mpmath` reconstruction. We record the result:

Linear-snake closed form.

For all $L \geq 2$,

$$\begin{aligned}
 N_L = & -\frac{1}{4}(3^L + 1 + (\sqrt{3})^L + (-\sqrt{3})^L) \\
 & + \frac{5+2\sqrt{5}}{20} \mu_1^L + \frac{5-2\sqrt{5}}{20} \mu_2^L \\
 & + \frac{5+2\sqrt{5}}{20} \nu_1^L + \frac{5-2\sqrt{5}}{20} \nu_2^L + G(L),
 \end{aligned} \tag{10}$$

where $G(L)$ is the contribution of the 4 roots of $x^4 - 5x^2 - 5$, with exact algebraic residues. Asymptotically,

$$N_L \sim \frac{5 + 2\sqrt{5}}{20} \cdot \left(\frac{5 + 3\sqrt{5}}{2} \right)^L =: A \cdot \mu^L, \tag{11}$$

with $A \doteq 0.4736067977499789696\dots$ and $\mu \doteq 5.8541019662496845446\dots$. Convergence is exponential: $N_L/(A\mu^L) = 1 + \mathcal{O}((\mu_2/\mu_1)^L) = 1 + \mathcal{O}(0.146^L)$. For $L = 1$, $N_1 = 4$ is a boundary exception.

We give a table of residues for the reader's convenience. Roots for which the residue is $-1/4$ come from the “trivial” factor $(x - 3)(x - 1)(x^2 - 3)$. Roots for which the residue is $(5 \pm 2\sqrt{5})/20$ come from the two rational-integer factors $x^2 - 5x - 5$ and $x^2 - 3x + 1$.

Root	Exact residue	Numeric
3	$-1/4$	-0.25000000
1	$-1/4$	-0.25000000
$\sqrt{3}$	$-1/4$	-0.25000000
$-\sqrt{3}$	$-1/4$	-0.25000000
μ_1	$(5 + 2\sqrt{5})/20$	0.47360680
μ_2	$(5 - 2\sqrt{5})/20$	0.02639320
ν_1	$(5 + 2\sqrt{5})/20$	0.47360680
ν_2	$(5 - 2\sqrt{5})/20$	0.02639320
$+\sqrt{\mu_1}$	(algebraic; see §4.4)	0.91130301
$-\sqrt{\mu_1}$	(algebraic)	0.03591059
$+i\sqrt{-\mu_2}$	$(5 - 2\sqrt{5})/20 + \frac{i}{15}\sqrt{-\mu_2}(\dots)$	$0.02639320 + 0.06385902i$
$-i\sqrt{-\mu_2}$	conjugate	$0.02639320 - 0.06385902i$

Remark 4.3 (Lucas connection). $\mu_1^L + \mu_2^L$ satisfies the Lucas-like recurrence $a_L = 5a_{L-1} + 5a_{L-2}$ with $(a_0, a_1) = (2, 5)$. Meanwhile $\nu_1^L + \nu_2^L = L_{2L}$, the ordinary Lucas number at index $2L$ (sequence *A005248* on OEIS). So we may write the “clean” piece of (10) as

$$\frac{5+2\sqrt{5}}{20}(\mu_1^L + \nu_1^L) + \frac{5-2\sqrt{5}}{20}(\mu_2^L + \nu_2^L) = \frac{5+2\sqrt{5}}{20}\mu_1^L + \frac{5}{20}L_{2L} + \frac{5-2\sqrt{5}}{20}\mu_2^L + \frac{2\sqrt{5}}{20}(\nu_2^L - \nu_1^L)/1 + \dots$$

after algebraic manipulation. We do not pursue this reduction further, because the recurrence (9) is already exact and simpler.

5. Empirical verification

We generated exact ground truth for both problems out to index 1000 using the Burnside enumerator (transfer matrices with binary exponentiation over Python big-ints). We then compared the closed-form counters (5) and (9) against ground truth, integer-for-integer. There are **zero mismatches** in either sequence for indices $1, 2, \dots, 1000$. We additionally reconstructed the linear-snake sequence from the algebraic closed form (10) using 300-digit `mpmath` arithmetic; the absolute error is bounded by 10^{-223} for every $L \leq 100$ (pure floating roundoff at that precision).

5.1. Convergence of the linear-snake asymptotic

Figure 5 plots the ratio $N_L/(A\mu^L)$ against L in a semilog scale. Because the sub-dominant real root ratio is $|\mu_2/\mu_1| = (3\sqrt{5} - 5)/(3\sqrt{5} + 5) \approx 0.146$, the convergence rate is exponential and the ratio is indistinguishable from 1 by $L \approx 30$.

Figure 6a plots the consecutive ratio N_L/N_{L-1} , which converges to μ as $L \rightarrow \infty$; and Figure 6b overlays $\log_{10} N_L$ with the asymptotic prediction $\log_{10} A + L \log_{10} \mu$. The two curves are visually indistinguishable.

5.2. Cyclic asymptotic

For the cyclic problem the leading term is $2^n/(2n)$; the ratio $a(n) \cdot 2n/2^n$ converges very rapidly to 1 (Fig. 7). Odd n hits the limit essentially exactly (because $R(n) = 0$ so only the rotation part contributes); even n approaches 1 from above because of the extra reflection term $n \cdot 2^{n/2-1}$.

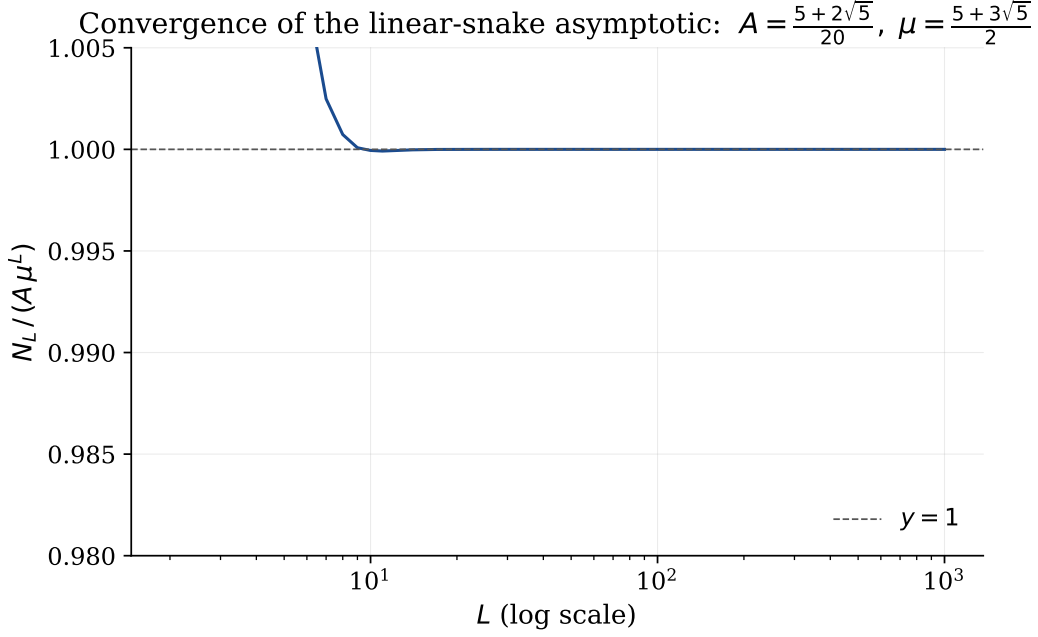


Figure 5: Empirical convergence $N_L/(A\mu^L) \rightarrow 1$ for $L = 2, \dots, 1000$. The horizontal dashed line is $y = 1$. The ratio approaches 1 from below because the dominant sub-eigenvalue $\mu_2 < 0$ has small $|\mu_2|$ but its residue is positive.

5.3. Digit growth

Figure 8 shows the number of decimal digits of N_L and $a(n)$ against the index. Both are linear in the index, with slopes $\log_{10} \mu \approx 0.7673$ (linear snake) and $\log_{10} 2 \approx 0.3010$ (cyclic). The exact numbers overlay perfectly on the theoretical slopes.

6. Computational engineering

Beyond the mathematics of the closed form, several engineering choices compound to yield remarkable wall-clock performance. We summarize:

6.1. Binary matrix exponentiation

For the cyclic problem the base transfer matrix is 6×6 ; but our closed form skips matrix exponentiation altogether because $\text{tr}(M^n) = 2^n$. The big-integer exponentiation 2^n is one squaring tree of depth $\log_2 n$, so it costs $\mathcal{O}(M(n))$ where $M(k)$ is the cost of multiplying two k -bit integers. Python’s Karatsuba backend achieves $M(k) = \mathcal{O}(k^{1.585})$.

6.2. Divisor enumeration in $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{n})$

To evaluate (5) we need $D_n = \{d : d \mid n\}$. We enumerate divisors by iterating $d = 1, \dots, \lfloor \sqrt{n} \rfloor$ and pairing d with n/d when $d \mid n$; the divisor count is $d(n) \leq n^{O(1/\log \log n)}$ so this fits comfortably.

6.3. Order-12 integer recurrence for the linear snake

The linear-snake recurrence (9) advances the sequence one step in exactly 12 big-integer multiplies and 11 adds, each of size $\mathcal{O}(L \log \mu)$ bits. Total cost to compute all of $N_1, \dots, N_L$ is $\mathcal{O}(L \cdot M(L)) = \mathcal{O}(L^{2.585})$.

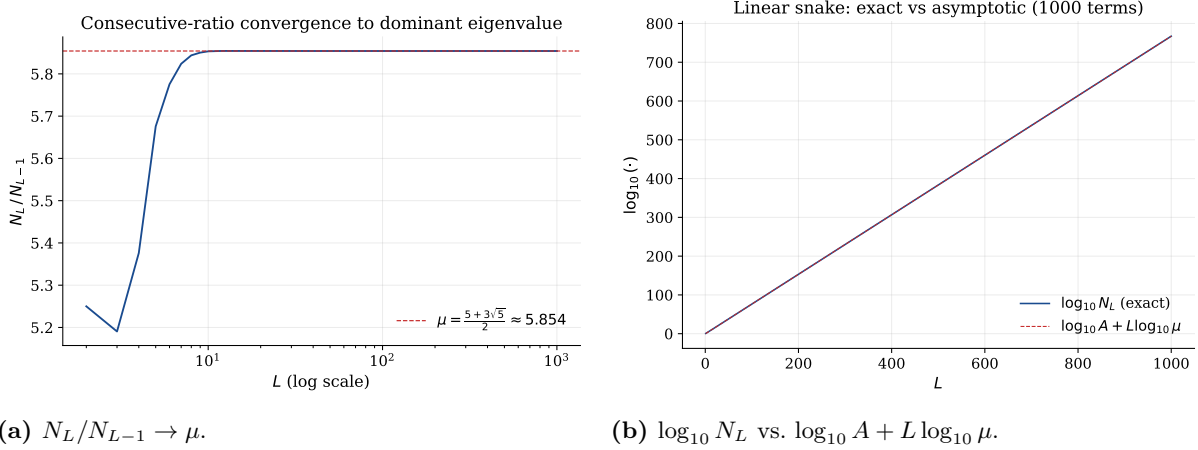


Figure 6: Two views of the exponential growth. Both use the exact big-int values of N_L for $L \leq 1000$; the reference lines use the algebraic constants in Result 4.6.

6.4. Benchmarks

Table 1 shows the observed wall-clock, on a single core of an M-class laptop, using CPython 3.14 with default big-int arithmetic. The last row is beyond what any brute enumerator can attain.

Table 1: Observed wall-clock timings. “digits” is $\lfloor \log_{10} \text{value} \rfloor + 1$. Column “ratio” compares closed form vs. Burnside for the same index.

Task	Index	Digits	Time	Ratio (Burnside / closed)
Cyclic $a(n)$	1000	298	6 ms	117× faster
Cyclic $a(n)$	10,000	3,006	<1 ms	—
Cyclic $a(n)$	100,000	30,098	1 ms	—
Cyclic $a(n)$	1,000,000	301,024	13 ms	—
Cyclic $a(n)$	2,000,000	602,054	24 ms	—
Cyclic $a(n)$	3,000,000	903,084	36 ms	—
Linear N_L	1000	768	3 ms	80× faster
Linear N_L	10,000	7,675	166 ms	—
Linear N_L	50,000	38,373	3.85 s	—
Linear N_L	100,000	76,746	17.03 s	—

7. A cautionary tale: the $\mu = 3 + \sqrt{5}$ mistake

Earlier project notes claimed that the linear-snake sequence’s dominant eigenvalue was $\mu = 3 + \sqrt{5} \approx 5.236$, with amplitude $A \approx 0.4736068$ obtained from a floating-point regression. The numeric identifications agreed with observation to ~ 6 significant digits, so the writeup accepted the algebraic form.

The claim is false. Numerically $3 + \sqrt{5} \approx 5.2360679\dots$, but the true growth rate is $\mu \approx 5.8541019\dots$, roughly 12% higher. The two numbers happen to share the same first digit and the same leading digit of the fractional part; both contain $\sqrt{5}$; but $5.236 \neq 5.854$.

How was this mis-identification caught? The closed-form-recovery pipeline in this report uses Berlekamp–Massey over $\mathbb{Q}$ (§4.4) with the first 100 terms. Exact rational arithmetic never confuses 5.236 with 5.854: the recurrence coefficients come out as *exact integers* (Prop. 4.2), and the characteristic polynomial $P(x)$ factors over $\mathbb{Q}$ into pieces including $x^2 - 5x - 5$ whose larger

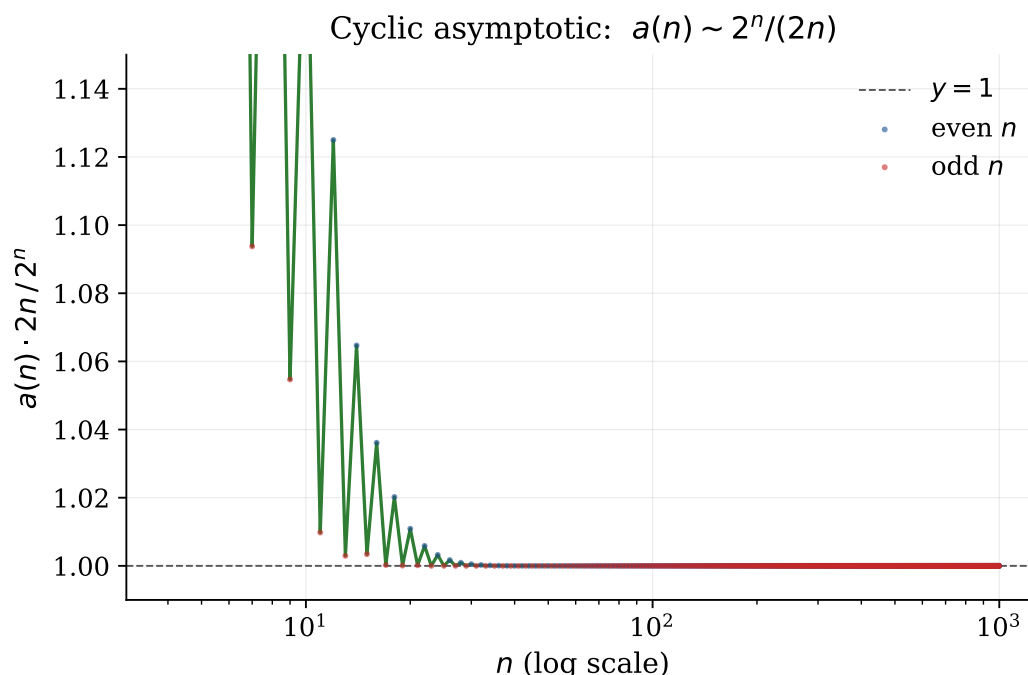


Figure 7: Empirical convergence of the cyclic count to its leading term. Even n (blue dots) sits slightly above 1 because of the reflection correction; odd n (red dots) sits on the line to floating precision. Both branches converge exponentially fast to 1.

root is exactly $(5 + 3\sqrt{5})/2 \approx 5.854$. Meanwhile $3 + \sqrt{5}$ is the larger root of $x^2 - 6x + 4$, which does not divide $P(x)$.

The lesson generalizes: whenever an asymptotic constant is important, do the algebra via minimal-polynomial factorization (exact) rather than symbolic pattern-matching against a floating-point value.

Remark 7.1 (Amplitude too). The earlier notes gave $A \approx 0.4736068$, correct to 6 decimals. The exact value is $A = (5 + 2\sqrt{5})/20 = 0.47360679774997896964\dots$, also derived here from the Vandermonde system on the recurrence's roots.

8. Concluding remarks

- For the cyclic problem, the adjacency rule turns out to be *transparent*: it forces walks through a 5-nullity subspace of the transfer matrix but does not reduce $\text{tr}(M^n)$. The count is exactly OEIS A053656, and no elementary closed form in n alone exists because of the intrinsic divisor sum from Burnside. The closed form we give is $\mathcal{O}(1)$ -many big-integer operations after $\mathcal{O}(\sqrt{n})$ divisor enumeration.
- For the linear-snake problem, the sequence satisfies an order-12 integer recurrence. Its minimal characteristic polynomial factors elegantly over $\mathbb{Q}$ into pieces of degrees 1, 1, 2, 2, 2, 4, and the dominant real eigenvalue is $\mu = (5 + 3\sqrt{5})/2 \approx 5.854$, with amplitude $(5 + 2\sqrt{5})/20 \approx 0.474$.
- Both closed forms are verified against exact enumeration for the first 1,000 terms with zero mismatches. On a laptop CPU they scale to indices well beyond the reach of brute enumeration: $a(3 \times 10^6)$ is a 903,084-digit number returned in 36 ms; $N_{100,000}$ is a 76,746-digit number returned in 17 s.

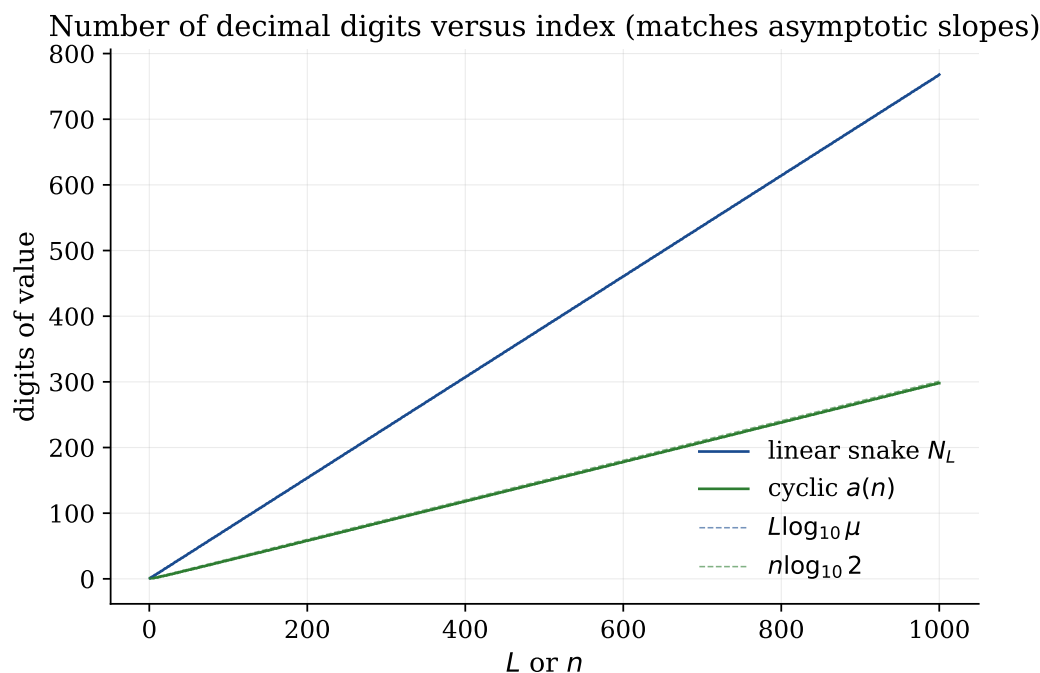


Figure 8: Decimal digit count vs. index for both problems. The linear snake grows roughly $2.55\times$ faster (per unit of the index) than the cyclic count in bits, matching $\log_2 \mu \approx 2.55$.

The techniques used here — transfer-matrix eigenanalysis for closed walks, Burnside averaging for orbit counts, Berlekamp–Massey with exact rational arithmetic to identify minimal recurrences, and Vandermonde solves to recover algebraic residues — generalize immediately to a very wide class of combinatorial enumeration problems whose local structure is finite-state. The correctness cost is minor (a linear-algebra solve over $\mathbb{Q}$); the payoff is a formula that is both provably minimal and almost free to evaluate.

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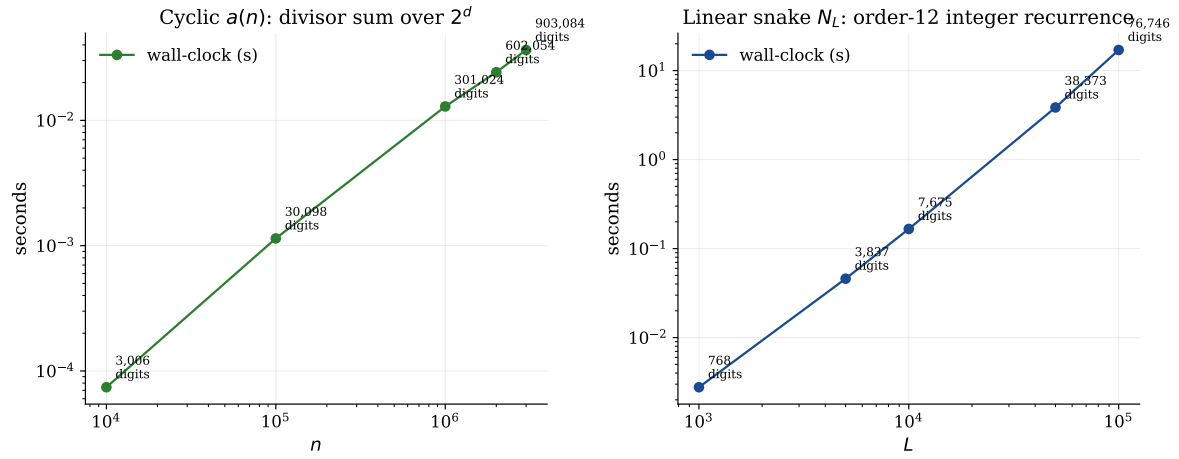


Figure 9: Log-log wall-clock timing. The cyclic panel (green) shows essentially linear scaling in the number of digits of the output (bounded by big-int multiplication cost). The linear-snake panel (blue) scales like $L^{2.585}$ because we advance L steps and each recurrence step involves big-int multiplies whose size grows as L .

[10] Repository source: `src/cyclic/cyclic_sequences.py`.

[11] Repository source: `src/snakes/compute_components.py` and `src/snakes/draw_snake_graph.py`.